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Sleepless Nights, A Public Health Challenge

Sleepless nights, a public health challenge

RISING TEMPERATURES are keeping Indians up at night. A recent study by a US-based climate advocacy group, which assessed the loss of sleeping hours in over 1,300 cities across the world, has found that the average person has lost nearly 56 hours of sleep annually between 2020 and 2025 due to unusually high night-time temperatures. At least 10 per cent of this sleep loss is directly attributable to climate change. In some of India's largest cities, people are losing significantly more sleep than the global average, from 93 hours in Chennai to 84 hours in Mumbai and 67 hours in Delhi. As summers get longer, hotter and more humid, these findings should be seen as a warning. Sleep is often treated as an individual problem to be fixed with better lifestyle choices. But when the environment makes rest difficult, sleep becomes a public health challenge.

Heat is just one of the factors that is causing Indians to toss and turn in their beds. A review of literature on sleep disorders, published last year in the *Indian Journal of Public Health*, found a widespread prevalence of sleep disorders across India. Sleep loss/deprivation connected to rapidly changing lifestyles, excessive screen time, social-media addiction, erratic eating habits and shift-based work schedules compound the challenges. Sleep is essential for cellular repair, immune function and regulating inflammation. Even modest reductions in sleep, when repeated over weeks or months, can have lasting effects, with chronic sleep deprivation being associated with hypertension, diabetes, heart disease, obesity and cognitive impairment, while also reducing workplace productivity and increasing the risk of accidents.

India needs to recognise healthy sleep as an essential pillar of public health. Heat action plans should account not only for day-time exposure but also for dangerously warm nights, particularly in dense urban settlements where the heat island effect is strongest. Urban planning, affordable cooling solutions and better housing design all have a role. Equally important is integrating sleep health into public health campaigns. As India deals with non-communicable diseases, protecting the country's sleep may prove to be an important investment in its long-term health.

Sleepless Nights, A Public Health Challenge

● Study & Findings

- US-based climate advocacy group assessed sleep loss across over 1,300 cities worldwide
- Average person lost nearly 56 hours of sleep annually between 2020 and 2025 due to high night-time temperatures
- At least 10% of this sleep loss is directly attributable to climate change

● City-wise Data (India)

- Chennai: 93 hours lost; Mumbai: 84 hours; Delhi: 67 hours all above the global average

● Underlying Drivers

- Longer, hotter, more humid summers intensified by the urban heat island effect
- Compounded by screen time, social-media addiction, erratic eating habits, and shift-based work

● Health Stakes

- Sleep is essential for cellular repair, immune function, and regulating inflammation
- Chronic sleep deprivation linked to hypertension, diabetes, heart disease, obesity, and cognitive impairment

● Policy Ask

- Heat action plans should account for dangerously warm nights, not just daytime exposure
- Need for affordable cooling solutions, better urban housing design, and integration into public health campaigns

Sleepless Nights, A Public Health Challenge

● What is Sleep Health

- Adequate, quality sleep (7–9 hours for adults) is essential for physiological and cognitive restoration
- Sleep cycles (REM and Non-REM) regulate memory consolidation, metabolism, and immunity

● Urban Heat Island (UHI) Effect

- Concrete surfaces, reduced vegetation, and human activity make cities warmer than surrounding areas, especially at night
- Persistently warm nights (“tropical nights”) prevent the body's natural cooling needed for sleep onset

● Heat Action Plans (HAPs) in India

- First introduced in Ahmedabad (2013) after the 2010 heatwave deaths; now adopted by multiple states under NDMA guidance
- Current plans focus mostly on daytime advisories, water stations, and early warning systems

● Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs) Link

- India faces a rising burden of NCDs : diabetes, hypertension, cardiovascular disease
- WHO recognises inadequate sleep as a contributing behavioural risk factor for NCDs

SC Urges Railways to Look Into Overcrowded Trains

SC urges Railways to look into issue of overcrowded trains

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday flagged the persistent menace of overcrowding on trains, urging the Railways to deploy youth on the ground to stop people from travelling on footboards.

The court refused to lay the blame for congested trains entirely on the Railways. It said passengers had an equal responsibility. Despite repeated deaths and tragedies, the court said, train-travelling “daredevils” refuse to reform.

“People still insist on being daredevils in catching trains and making their way from one place to another. True that most of these choices are informed by one or the other practical consideration, but the risk stares one right in the face. Sometimes, practical considerations must give way to the preservation of life,” a Bench headed by Justice Sanjay Karol observed in a judgment.

The court further asked the Railways to reconsider the “second-class” nomenclature attached to passengers as an anachronism alien to the Constitution’s egalitarian spirit.

The judgment stems



The judgment stems from an appeal by Lata, whose husband died after falling from a train.

from an appeal filed by Lata, whose husband died in November 2015 after falling from a moving train. Represented by advocate Shweta Priyadarshini, Lata had previously been denied compensation by both the Railway Claims Tribunal and the Madhya Pradesh High Court because no train ticket had been recovered from her husband’s body.

The court said the Railways, although a facet of colonial inheritance, serves as the “backbone of the nation”. It is the largest civil employer in the country, and should not resort to technical approaches over compensation.

The court ordered the Railways to pay ₹8 lakh as compensation to Lata.

SC Urges Railways to Look Into Overcrowded Trains

● Supreme Court Observations

- A Bench headed by Justice Sanjay Karol flagged the persistent menace of overcrowding on trains
- Urged the Railways to deploy youth on the ground to stop people travelling on footboards
- Held that passengers share equal responsibility; described train-travelling “daredevils” as unwilling to reform

● Judicial Directions

- Asked Railways to reconsider the “second-class” nomenclature as an anachronism alien to the Constitution's egalitarian spirit
- Case arose from an appeal by Lata, whose husband died in November 2015 after falling from a moving train
- She had earlier been denied compensation by the Railway Claims Tribunal and the Madhya Pradesh High Court for want of a recovered ticket

India's Funds, Talent, and the Opening for a Research Leap

India now has the funds, the talent and the opening for a research leap



SHIVKUMAR KALYANARAMAN
AND V ANANTHA NAGESWARAN

FOR THREE months this spring, the most consequential number in the Indian economy was the distance between a tanker and the Strait of Hormuz. When the strait closed in March, a country that imports the overwhelming share of the oil it uses found its lifeline pinched at a single point and rerouted at a cost to longer voyages for Russian crude. The lesson was salutary, but incomplete. In the end, oil can be rerouted. A nation that is aspiring to be self-reliant in critical technologies enjoys no such latitude.

The deeper lesson is not that supply chains are fragile, but that they have become instruments of policy — an export licence a lever, a chokepoint a weapon, a technology freely traded one year, an object of denial the next. China spends 2.43 per cent of its output on research and development, three-quarters of it financed by its own companies, with one ambition: To end its dependence on technologies others control and deepen the world's dependence on those it controls.

India knows where it stands, because it has taken its own measure without flinching. As of 2023, it spends 0.64 per cent of GDP on research and development — against a global average more than twice that — and

barely two-fifths of even that is financed by private enterprise, whereas in China, Korea and America the share is three-quarters or more. However, the state has, for the first time, put real weight behind the proposition.

The Anusandhan National Research Foundation, notified in 2024 — a statutory body chaired by the Prime Minister, convening academia, industry, start-ups, philanthropy and the diaspora — exists to change the arithmetic of risk. Its Research, Development and Innovation Fund commits Rs 1 lakh crore over six years to the private sector alone, a fund of funds supplying patient capital built to outlast the quarterly cycle; its ANRF Core adds Rs 50,000 crore over five years for underlying science. The design is catalytic: For every rupee companies invest in pre-commercial research in partnership with the foundation, they are likely to commit five to 10 of their own to commercialise and scale up these research outputs. All-of-government and all-of-society collaboration is a means to higher productivity and impact for all parties. And it goes beyond the cheque, aligning government procurement and regulation with the landscape it is building.

A firm may enter as a limited partner alongside the foundation's anchor capital in a second-level fund manager; participate directly as an eligible technology entity; or do so through a joint venture with start-ups and the global capability centres (GCCs) already here. On the science side, it may partner on a national mission, set a pre-competitive challenge for the foundation to co-fund, route its corporate social responsibility (CSR) through the ANRF Innovation Fund, or

share the cost of a single project before committing further. So many doors exist for one reason: The threshold should never be what keeps a willing firm outside.

But the argument must move on from what is offered to what is required, for a catalyst is not a substitute, or a crutch. The foundation can lower the risk of the climb; it cannot make it. Three acts remain the industry's own. The first is to mobilise one's own capital behind the public catalyst. The second is to choose, with strategic seriousness, the arenas that matter — the technologies in which dependence is most dangerous and capability most valuable — over the incremental gains a captive market rewards. The third, least glamorous and most important, is institutional: To build inside the firm the machinery long-horizon goals demand — dedicated research units, corporate venture arms, planning functions insulated from the tyranny of the next quarter. India can be the world's research and development partner. All of us have to build it together. The foundation's logic is partnership with academia and deep-technology start-ups that outpace incumbents. Building it yields a dividend, no income statement records: Employment, for the doctoral talent India trains at cost and too readily watches depart, with the world-class research culture and context.

Indian industry can rise to such a challenge and history provides the evidence. When India accepted the World Trade Organisation's intellectual property regime in the mid-1990s, agreeing to honour product patents in pharmaceuticals, the expectation was that the

domestic drug industry, built on reverse-engineering molecules others had discovered, would be overrun by the very multinationals whose patents it had worked around. That is not what happened. Indian firms chose to build rather than retreat: They mastered process chemistry and the world's strictest regulatory requirements, and made themselves the pharmacy for much of the world. The inflection now before Indian enterprise is broader; its logic is identical.

The climb, moreover, can be swifter than it was for those who went before. India faces the task with the pieces in place at once — a demographic dividend available now, not forever; unmatched digital public infrastructure; funds and architecture now in place; and a global moment that rewards any economy offering an alternative to a single dominant supplier. These are the conditions under which a country does not merely catch up but leaps — from the consumer of intellectual property it has too long been, to the generator its aspirations demand. But the window is the one thing the state cannot hold open alone. Hormuz showed what it costs to depend on others for what one needs; the technological independence that will enhance resilience and, eventually, build indispensability can be achieved only by building capabilities from the ground up. The state has walked the first stretch of that road; the laboratories are ready; the capital is available, and industry's commitment will complete the compact.

The writers are respectively the CEO of the Anusandhan National Research Foundation and the Chief Economic Advisor to the Government of India. Views are personal

All of us have to build it together: The foundation's logic is partnership with academia and deep-technology start-ups that outpace incumbents

India's Funds, Talent, and the Opening for a Research Leap

● India's R&D Gap

- India spends 0.64% of GDP on R&D (2023), against a global average more than twice that; China spends 2.43%
- Only about two-fifths of India's R&D is financed by private enterprise, versus three-quarters or more in China, Korea, and the US

● What's Required Next

- Industry must mobilise its own capital behind the public catalyst
- Strategic choice of technologies where import-dependence is most dangerous and capability most valuable
- Institutional machinery within firms dedicated research units, corporate venture arms insulated from quarterly pressures

India's Funds, Talent, and the Opening for a Research Leap

Anusadhan National Research Foundation

It was established through the Anusandhan National Research Foundation Act, 2023.

It is functioning under the Department of Science & Technology (DST).

The Science and Engineering Research Board (SERB) has been merged into ANRF.

It acts as an apex body to provide high-level strategic direction of scientific research in the country as per recommendations of the National Education Policy.

Funding Target: It aims to mobilise funds amounting to ₹50,000 crore during 2023–28 through multiple streams including the ANRF Fund, Innovation Fund, Science and Engineering Research Fund, and Special Purpose Funds.

Preparing the roadmap for short, medium, and long-term research and development.

Seeding, growing, and facilitating research at academic and research institutions, particularly at universities and colleges where research capacity is at a nascent stage, through programs such as research and development projects, fellowships, academic chairs, and creation of centers of excellence.

J&K's Manasbal Lake Starts Hosting Migratory Birds Again

J&K's Mansbal lake starts hosting migratory birds again

Peerzada Ashiq

SRINAGAR

Manasbal Lake, the country's deepest freshwater lake in central Kashmir's Ganderbal district, is on the path of ecological recovery with the return of migratory birds.

The lake is 43-feet deep with a length and breadth of 3.5 km and 1.5 km, respectively. Locals are upbeat about the uptick in the migratory birds between December 2025 and January 2026.

"The return of migratory birds prompted the Wular-Manasbal Development Authority (WMDA) to hold a bird watching festival in the winter. Many rare species were sighted by the birdwatchers," said Chief Executive Officer of the WMDA Ahsanul Haq Chishti.

According to official da-



Locals are upbeat about the uptick in the migratory birds in Mansbal Lake between December 2025 and January 2026. FILE PHOTO

ta, the Mansbal lake was home to more than 46 species of birds belonging to 23 families, including Mallard, White Headed Duck, Eurasian Hoopee, Eurasian Collared Dove, Lesser Pied Kingfisher, Golden Eagle, Grey Backed Shrike, Tickell's Thrush etc.

Efforts paid off

Reviving the lake played a major role in arrival of migratory birds. "Accumulated weeds on about 7202.50

cubic meters were removed from the lake surface. "The lake with clear waters and long strips of water channels is rejuvenating," said Mr. Chisti. What has added to the health of the lake is the dredging process over an area of around 70,000 square feet, "restoring freshness, clearing channels and maintaining the lake's depth".

"Weeding operations managed to control the ex-

cessive growth of aquatic vegetation that had severely impacted water circulation and biodiversity of the lake," said Mr. Chisti.

Bilal Nasir Zargar, a wildlife photographer from Mansbal, said about five years ago, there was a dip in the lake's water level, resulting in lesser migratory birds stopping by.

"However, I have again started spotting migratory birds like Horned Grib and Long-Eared Owl and others too, especially the last winter. In the last two years, water quality has improved. I expect more migratory birds to flock. The lake, however, needs attention on multiple aspects," said Mr. Zargar, who has documented the migratory birds from the last 12 years at the lake.

Meanwhile, the WMDA has pushed for water budgeting "to know the quan-

tum of the lake's carrying capacity, volume of water currently being lifted by way of water supply schemes, natural outflows or other drawls and the surplus quantum available with the waterbody".

Water budgeting

The water budgeting will be carried out by the J&K Water Resources Regulatory Authority. "The idea is that the water ecosystem of the lake is preserved and kept at a scientifically derived level to maintain its ecology," said Mr. Chishti.

A three-pronged approach has been adopted to further improve the water quality in the lake. According to officials, a sewerage treatment plant and an integrated solid waste management plant spread over one acre of land, will treat the waste before entering into the lake.

J&K's Manasbal Lake Starts Hosting Migratory Birds Again

● Ecological Recovery

- Manasbal Lake in Ganderbal district, Kashmir the country's deepest freshwater lake is on a path of ecological recovery
- Migratory birds are returning after a dip in numbers observed roughly five years ago

● Restoration Efforts

- The Wullar-Manasbal Development Authority (WMDA) held a winter bird-watching festival; over 46 bird species from 23 families were recorded
- Dredging over an area of about 70,000 square feet removed roughly 7,202.50 cubic metres of accumulated weeds, restoring water channels and depth

Battling Drug Abuse: Kerala's Coordinated Anti-Cartel Push

Battling drug abuse

Kerala has shown initiative in coordinated action against cartels

For a few years now, a growing section of Kerala's youth has been consumed by a festering addiction to narcotic drugs and contraband/psychotropic substances. The signs of the State teetering towards substance abuse were apparent in the wake of the liquor ban a decade ago. But it grew to gargantuan proportions with synthetic drug cartels using digital technologies and social media to outpace law enforcement. While the COVID-19-stricken years of 2020-21 saw a drop in NDPS cases registered in the State, cases surged to 26,619 in 2022 from 5,695 in 2021. The number rose to 36,314 in 2025, alongside large-scale seizures of commercial quantities of contraband. Commercial capital Ernakulam city accounted for a substantial number. Despite efforts by multiple agencies, success has been limited. The UDF government sought to streamline the anti-drug enforcement drive by launching Operation Toofan in June, with the State police joining hands with the police forces in the southern States, central agencies, and State education, health and excise departments.

Focusing on integrated enforcement, public engagement, rehabilitation of victims and a speedy and effective prosecution, the operation has, until July 15, netted over 7,600 drug peddlers in some 7,100 cases, with synthetic drugs accounting for a significant share of the haul. Given that narcotics cases are often weakened by questionable forensic reliability, the issue has gained sharp focus during the ongoing campaign. The network of drug cartels is often too intricately webbed, with investigations often netting only the small fish. Besides bringing the community on board as Toofan warriors, the campaign aims to strengthen national intelligence-sharing and coordination systems under the NCORD framework, including the NIDAAN database of arrested narco-offenders. Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala is meeting Chief Ministers to solicit jointness in the operations. The States are in the process of assigning nodal officers for close coordination, with a platform in the pipeline. Since the rackets employ innovative means to recruit carriers, coordinate among themselves and carry out delivery, Kerala needs to upskill the District Anti-Narcotics Special Action Force (DANSAF) personnel at the cutting edge to bust these networks. Equally important is to strengthen cyber forensic capabilities so that neither investigation nor prosecution is found wanting in taking these cases to their logical conclusion. The crippling effects of narcotics on society are manifold, and it is never too late to build a defence against them.

Battling Drug Abuse: Kerala's Coordinated Anti-Cartel Push

● Rising Substance Abuse Trend

- NDPS cases in Kerala surged from 5,695 in 2021 to 26,619 in 2022, rising further to 36,314 in 2025, alongside large seizures
- Ernakulam city accounts for a substantial share of cases; synthetic drug cartels use digital platforms and social media to outpace enforcement

● Operation Toofan

- The UDF government launched Operation Toofan in June, integrating State police, southern-state police forces, central agencies, and the education, health, and excise departments
- Until July 15, the operation had netted over 7,600 drug peddlers in about 7,100 cases, with synthetic drugs forming a significant share of seizures

● Coordination Framework

- Strengthening intelligence-sharing under the **NCORD (Narco-Coordination) framework**, including the **NIDAAN database** of arrested narco-offenders
- Kerala's Home Minister is meeting other Chief Ministers to build inter-state coordination; nodal officers are being assigned

Battling Drug Abuse: Kerala's Coordinated Anti-Cartel Push

- **NDPS Act, 1985**

- The Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act is India's primary law criminalising production, possession, sale, and trafficking of narcotic and psychotropic substances

- **NCORD Mechanism**

- The Narco-Coordination Centre is a multi-tier mechanism (Centre, State, District) set up by the Ministry of Home Affairs for inter-agency coordination on drug enforcement

- **Institutional Architecture**

- It is the nodal drug law enforcement and intelligence agency under the Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India. It was constituted on 14th November, 1985, under the provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985 (NDPS Act).

The Delimitation Debate Is a Fight Over the Wrong Number

The delimitation debate is a fight over the wrong number



PRAVEEN CHAKRAVARTY

PARLIAMENT'S FIRST power is the power of the purse: Its central task is to scrutinise how money is collected and where it goes. Money is raised from taxes and logically, richer states contribute more. It is then spent on people's welfare and justifiably, poorer states receive more.

Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Telangana contribute roughly 20 per cent of all taxes (direct plus indirect) while Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh contribute 6 per cent. Clearly, the three richer southern states account for significantly higher contributions to the Union government's tax kitty. Five years ago, the three southern states contributed 18 per cent to the nation's taxes while the latter group of states accounted for 7 per cent. So, the share of the southern states in India's tax revenues is only rising while that of the latter is declining.

At the same time, these three southern states account for 13 per cent of the population while the three northern states account for 33 per cent. Ten years ago, the three southern states had 14 per cent of India's population and the northern states 32 per cent. Ten years from now, only 12 per cent of the population will be from these southern states and 34 per cent from the latter group of northern states. Evidently, the share of population of southern states is only decreasing while that of the latter is increasing. So, in India, states' share of revenues and population seem to go in opposite directions.

Poorer states need greater funds and are also more populous with higher birth rates. Richer states contribute more money and tend to be less populous with falling birth rates. If the financial oversight function of Parliament includes both collecting and spending money, then isn't it logical to expect representation for states proportionate to their contribution to tax collections as well as to their spending needs? Put simply, why

is a state's share of contribution to the Union tax kitty not a factor in determining its share of representation in Parliament, while only its share of population is counted as a factor? Especially when the share of contribution and population are inversely related.

The idea of a population-based representative democracy with a decadal census to measure the size of population and redraw constituencies was right at a time of rampant slavery and agrarian economies in 1787, when James Madison drafted it in the US Constitution. Back then, an elected representative physically carried the concerns of a fixed body of people, and there were natural limits to how many one person could reach, canvass and answer to. Roughly equal numbers of people per seat were a fair proxy for roughly equal access and equal voice.

But what is so sacrosanct about it being the sole determinant of share of representation today? In 2026, a Member of Parliament who wants to reach her voters does not walk the district. She sends a message, and it lands with 100,000 people or a million for the same effort and the same cost. The point is

What is so sacrosanct about it being the sole determinant of share of representation today? In 2026, a Member of Parliament who wants to reach her voters does not walk the district. She sends a message



ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHI

deliberately provocative: Population is no longer a good measure of the burden of representation, because technology has dissolved that burden.

"Equal population per seat" bundles two different claims. One is practical: A representative can only serve so many, so seats should be sized to a manageable number. The other is moral: Every citizen is equal, so every vote should carry equal weight. Technology has hollowed out the first claim. It has not touched the second. No one can argue that an Indian in Kanpur deserves less voice than an Indian in Coimbatore.

This is not a plea to let rich states buy votes, nor to price a citizen's franchise by her tax receipt. Every individual's vote stays exactly equal. But delimitation is not about the individual vote. It is about the collective weight of a state in the national legislature — and in a federation, that cannot be settled by headcount alone. So, the question is not whether every citizen should count equally — of course they should — but whether a state's collective leverage in Parliament should track only its population or be more holistic.

Parliament's job is to decide how

the Union's money is raised and spent. States that supply a larger share of that money must be given their due share of voice in Parliament. But this does not mean money should be the only measure. This is of course not a call to hark back to the days of voting rights only for taxpayers. It is a call for the Delimitation Commission to come to terms with the realities of 21st-century Indian federalism and arrive at a more comprehensive formula for share in Parliament just as the Finance Commission does for share in taxes.

The current formula of a population-only based delimitation exercise only elicits warped and regressive ideas such as Chandrababu Naidu and M K Stalin urging families in their states to have more children and coming up with "PLI" schemes for "baby production". Not out of any theory of human flourishing, but just to defend seats in a future delimitation and prevent migrant labour from other states.

Change the denominator and the whole conversation changes with it. No chief minister has to treat childbirth as a seat-protection strategy. If share of taxes is also factored in for share in Parliament, then the other vexatious issue of inter-state migration will become less political. After all, migrant labour contributes to the economy and taxes of the state. There is already an irony in the arithmetic: Much of the tax revenue Karnataka and Tamil Nadu remit is generated by workers who migrated from the very states now poised to gain seats, and who are still counted in the populations they left.

And so, the argument between states shifts from babies and migrants to development and finance, which is the argument a serious federation ought to be having in the first place.

The delimitation fight is a fight over the wrong number — which census year to use? The real question is: Should population be the sole determinant of parliamentary representation? The denominator should be some combination of population and economic contribution that reflects not just how many people a state has, but how much their state contributes to the national whole.

The writer is a Member of Parliament, chairman of All India Professionals' Congress, and visiting professor, Ashoka University

The Delimitation Debate Is a Fight Over the Wrong Number

● The Core Argument

- The author argues the delimitation debate wrongly fixates on population alone as the sole basis for parliamentary seat-share
- Southern states (Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana) contribute roughly 20% of all taxes while northern states (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh) contribute about 6%, yet southern population share is falling while the northern share is rising

● Population vs Contribution Mismatch

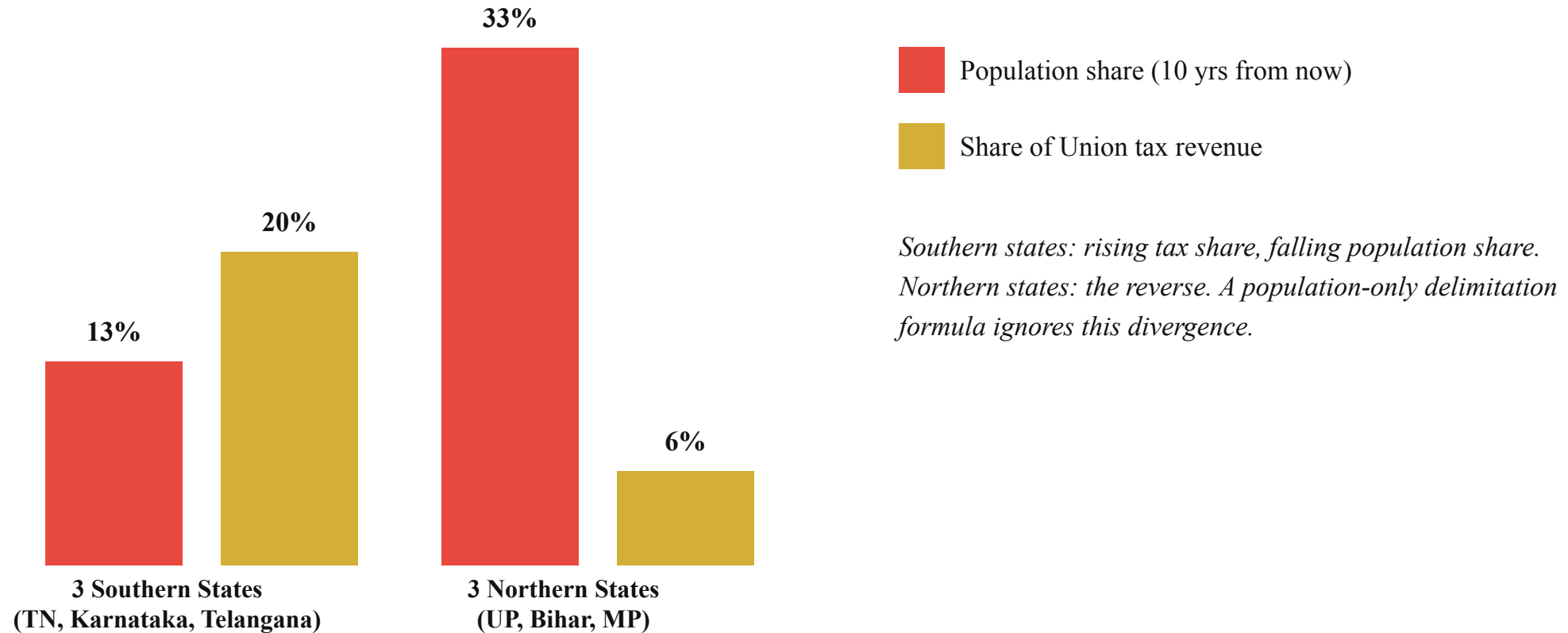
- Southern states' population share is projected to fall from about 13% to 12%, while northern states' share is projected to rise from about 32% to 34%, over a ten-year window
- The author calls for the Delimitation Commission to weigh a composite formula of population and economic contribution, akin to how the Finance Commission allocates devolution

● Warped Incentives Highlighted

- A purely population-based formula has already prompted proposals to incentivise higher birth rates in southern states to protect future seat share

The Delimitation Debate Is a Fight Over the Wrong Number

Population Share vs Tax Contribution



India Rejects Former Japan Minister's Remarks on Bullet Train Delay

India rejects former Japan Minister's remarks on bullet train project delay

Maitri Porecha

NEW DELHI

Japan will provide its next-generation E10 series Shinkansen trains to India for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail (MAHSR) project, official spokespersons from the Ministries of External Affairs and Railways said on Friday, addressing queries on the status of the project.

“India-Japan discussions on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high speed train are progressing well. Japan will provide E10 series train in the early 2030s. The train is still under development. Meanwhile, construction work is rapidly progressing. First section will be opened in 2027,” a spokesperson from the Ministry of Railways said.

The clarification comes in response to a recent crit-



Need for speed: An artist's impression of the future E10 series of the Shinkansen. EAST JAPAN RAILWAY COMPANY/TANGERINE

ical social media post by a former Japanese Minister regarding the project, which will be India's first bullet train network. In the post, Hideki Makiyama, a member of Japan's ruling Liberal Democratic Party, had blamed New Delhi for the timeline delays. He had also flagged concerns over the Japanese side allegedly being “excluded from the signalling system” of the high-speed network.

The MEA clarified that the statement represented an “individual opinion” that stands at “considerable variance with facts.”

Launch in 2027

Japan has been playing a key role in the implementation of the mega project in terms of financing it as well as sharing technology, and engineering expertise. Railway officials said that India and Japan had agreed

to start the operations with an Indian high-speed train, which is slated to run at an operational speed of 280 kmph. The train is currently being developed indigenously by BEM Limited and the Integral Coach Factory. “We will start off by using the indigenous train because India wants to make the Surat-Bilimora section in Gujarat operational by August 2027, and the Japanese E10 trains will only arrive in 2030,” officials said.

Civil construction work along the 508-km corridor has accelerated rapidly, officials said. The Railway Ministry has awarded a tender to German multinational Siemens for installation of signalling systems along the bullet train corridor stretch, with a view to start the operations by 2027.

(With PTI inputs)

India Rejects Former Japan Minister's Remarks on Bullet Train Delay

● Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail (MAHSR)

- India's first bullet train project, a 508 km corridor between Mumbai and Ahmedabad, using Japanese Shinkansen technology under a 2015 India-Japan agreement
- Funded largely through a low-interest soft loan from the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA), implemented by the National High Speed Rail Corporation Limited (NHSRCL)

● Shinkansen Technology

- Japan's high-speed rail system, in operation since 1964, renowned for speed, safety record, and precision

● India's Indigenous High-Speed Rail Push

- BEML and the Integral Coach Factory (ICF) are developing India's own high-speed trainsets under “Make in India,” reducing dependence on imported rolling stock for initial operations

● India-Japan Strategic Partnership

- MAHSR is a flagship project under the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership, symbolising technology transfer and infrastructure cooperation

Thank You